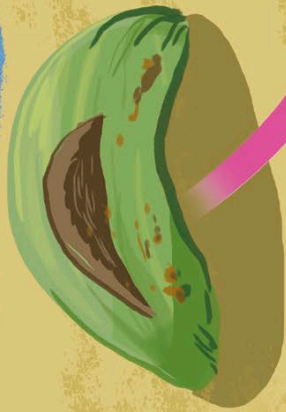


Tough drupe

The coconut fruit is called a drupe. Beneath its smooth skin is a thick brown husk made of fibers. The husk surrounds a single seed.



As the drupe breaks open, shoots and roots grow from the coconut seed.

The drupe floats thanks to air trapped in the husk. Protective layers keep it from being damaged by seawater.

See also

Find out about the dandelion (60-61), whose seeds are spread by the wind, and the orchid (58-59) and oak tree (62-63), whose seeds are spread by animals.

Roots and shoots

The white flesh and water inside the coconut provide food and moisture for the sprouting seed. A single shoot grows upward, while roots reach down into the soil.

Most of the roots are shallow—only a few go deeper. New roots grow throughout the tree's life, and adult palms may have up to 7,000.

Drupe Mango and peach trees also bear fruit called drupes. These fruits have a fleshy layer that surrounds a hard, woody shell, or “stone,” that contains the seed. Coconuts have a hard husk instead of a fleshy layer.



Palm oil Another type of palm tree—the oil palm—bears a fruit that produces oil. The oil is used to make many things, from chocolate to toothpaste. However, there is a problem: forests are being cut down to make way for oil palms, and endangered animals such as orangutans are losing their homes.

